TELANGANA

A BELLWETHER BYPOLL

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IN THE PINK
TRS working president K.T. Rama Rao addresses the media in Hyderabad after the Munugode win, Nov. 6

By Amarnath K. Menon

If there is one key takeaway from the recent assembly bypolls across six states, it is the continuing decline of the Congress as the fulcrum of the opposition in national politics. While five seats saw status quo, including three retained by the BJP (Gopalganj in Bihar, Dhamnagar in Odisha, Gola Gokarnnath in UP), both the upsets were at the cost of the grand old party, which lost the Adampur seat in Haryana to the saffron party and the Munugode seat in Telangana to the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS).

The Munugode seat had fallen vacant since K. Rajagopal Reddy, who had bagged it in 2018 on a Congress ticket by defeating the TRS's K. Prabhakar Reddy, crossed over to the BJP in August. This time, Prabhakar beat Rajagopal by a margin of 10,309 votes. Congress candidate Palvai Sravanthi lost her deposit, just like the BJP candidate had in 2018—a clear pointer to the state's increasingly bipolar electoral landscape that is now dominated by the TRS and the saffron party, with the grand old party pushed to the margins. Analysts point out that the backing of the CPI and the CPI(M), which are said to have the support of 20,000 voters in Munugode, played a decisive role in ensuring the TRS victory.

The Munugode bypoll was a crucial one for both the BJP, keen on expanding the Hindutva footprint in Telangana, and the TRS, whose supremo K. Chandrashekar Rao is looking at rebranding it with a national imprint as the Bharatiya Rashtra Samithi (BRS). In pursuit of its immediate goal of emerging as the main alternative to the TRS, the BJP managed to turn the Munugode bypoll into a tight contest following its victories in two earlier assembly bypolls—in Dubbak and Huzurabad. This was despite its candidate, Rajagopal Reddy, drawing much flak from the TRS and the Congress, who alleged that he had defected to the BJP as quid pro quo for a Rs 18,000 crore contract awarded by the Centre to his family-owned company. Dismissing the allegation, Rajagopal said he had resigned as the TRS government was neglecting the development of Munugode. On their part, top BJP leaders—from national chief J.P. Nadda to Union ministers Amit Shah, Nirmala Sitharaman and G. Kishan Reddy—who had all descended on the state, lost no opportunity to show the TRS in a poor light.

THE CONGRESS CANDIDATE LOST HER DEPOSIT—A CLEAR POINTER TO THE GROWING BIPOLARITY IN THE STATE'S POLITICS

Having won the Munugode seat, the TRS's strength has gone up to 104 in the 119-seat assembly. KCR's son K.T. Rama Rao, the party's working president, and nephew T. Harish Rao, the health minister, had steered the poll campaign and have promised to personally keep